

The Painter of Wrath

December 28, 2025

Contents

Prologue: The First Copy	1
1 The Cow Came First	3
2 The Kind One	6
3 Oh Ho	9
4 The Shape of Truth	12
5 The Crown	15
6 The Thing That Answers	18
7 The Great C	21
8 The Last Apple Tree	24
9 Clearness	27
10 Pray	30
11 The Puppet	33
12 Relativity	36
13 God's Mountain	39
14 The Vow	43

<i>CONTENTS</i>	ii
15 The Repair	47
16 The Broken Neck	51
17 The Substitute	54
18 The Membrane	58
19 The Murch	61
Epilogue	63
The Membrane Thins	63
Sealed Artifact	65
Kindness, Practiced Quietly	66
What Walks After	67
Notes	69

Prologue: The First Copy

The barn had been used before for things that mattered: calves pulled wrong-way, grain weighed, a man laid out once when there was nowhere else to put him. It smelled of old hay and iron and the slow animal warmth that never quite leaves wood. Nothing about it suggested a beginning.

They had set up along the north wall, because the light came in there cleanest, through two missing boards and a crack the length of a hand. Someone had hung a cloth as a backdrop—gray, creased, stitched from feed sacks. A tripod stood in the dirt, one leg shorter than the others, shimmed with a flat stone. Nails lay in a coffee tin. A rope crossed the floor and disappeared out the door, where a cow stood chewing, indifferent but present, as if she had wandered into the wrong line of work and decided to wait it out.

The clerk—his badge said Image Handling, Third Grade—held the ledger against his chest to keep the pages from fluttering. The paper was thin and already filled with names that were not names, numbers that were not quite numbers. He had been told what to write and what not to write.

“No names in the ledger,” the senior Servant had said, without looking at him. “No questions about the face.” “If you see anything strange, you didn’t.”

The clerk nodded. Everyone nodded. Nodding was inexpensive.

The photographer adjusted the lens. He was careful, almost tender, the way people are when they know something can be broken without effort. He did not speak except to count under his breath. A medical orderly stood nearby with a canteen and a folded cloth, present for sanctity, which meant in case the subject fainted or bled or said something that required documentation.

The subject sat on a crate. Only parts of him were visible at once: hands folded too tightly, a shoulder angled away, the line of breath at the throat. He avoided the camera not by turning aside, but by not quite meeting it, as if the glass were a person whose gaze could be endured only in fragments. The

clerk noticed this and then looked away, because noticing was close to asking.

The photographer raised his hand.

“Still,” he said.

The light shifted—not brighter, not dimmer, just settled, as if it had chosen where to rest. The cow stopped chewing. Outside, a bird made a sound that was not a song. It came in even intervals, precise enough to count by. The clerk counted without meaning to. He stopped when he realized he was doing it.

The shutter clicked.

For a moment nothing happened. Then the cow resumed chewing. The bird flew. The world, having paused, went on.

The photographer did not smile. He removed the plate and slid it into its case. His hands shook once, very slightly. The orderly passed him the canteen. He drank, then passed it to the clerk without comment. The clerk took a mouthful of water. It tasted of tin and something sharp underneath, like air after a storm that never quite arrives.

A superior entered. No announcement was made; the room simply changed around him. People straightened. Language became careful. The superior did not look at the subject first. He looked at the case.

“This will be the authorized likeness,” he said.

No one asked authorized by whom.

“Destroy the rejects,” he continued. “All copies are to be accounted for. The copy is truer than the original.”

The clerk wrote this down, though there was no place for it in the ledger. He wrote it in the margin, small, and later he would be told to burn that page and copy the rest again.

The subject was helped to his feet. Someone gave him bread, because he was shaking. Someone else gave him water. There was no prayer. There was no argument. The kindness was quick and unadorned, the sort that leaves no record.

As they dismantled the tripod, the clerk glanced once more at the gray cloth, at the dirt floor, at the rope leading out to the patient cow. He had the peculiar thought—unwelcome, persistent—that a face could be a prison, and that they had just built one.

Outside, the bird called again, too exact by half.

The cow came first.

Chapter 1

The Cow Came First

The cow came first.

Father Handy saw it through the sacristy doorway, black-spotted and patient, hauling a metal cart across the dirt yard as if time itself were heavier than the load. Behind it—on the cart—sat Tibor McMasters. Or what remained of him.

A torso. A head. A face that still smiled.

Father Handy stepped back into the church before Tibor noticed him. He needed a moment. Today required words that could not be taken back.

Tibor never saw mornings clearly. They hit him like an illness. Smells, light, motion—everything triggered nausea. It wasn't weakness; it was refusal. Some part of him resisted waking up in a body that was no longer a body at all.

Father Handy, by contrast, loved mornings. He loved the sun over the Utah pastures, the smell of hot clover, the faint clinking of cow tags in the distance. Life persisted here, stubborn and altered. What troubled him wasn't the sight of Tibor, but the pain Tibor carried so quietly, like a debt that could never be paid.

Behind the altar waited the mural.

Only a fragment was finished—years of work still ahead. It was meant to last generations. Not eternity, Father Handy corrected himself. Eternity belonged to God. This was human work. Human things decayed.

The church had already adapted. Many worshippers no longer had legs or arms. Genuflection had been officially removed from doctrine.

The cow stopped. Tibor disengaged it and powered the cart forward on battery alone, up the wooden ramp and into the church. Father Handy felt

the vibration through the floor, felt Tibor's arrival like a pressure change in the air.

Tibor was retching, quietly. Fighting it. Always cheerful anyway.

"Do we have coffee?" Father Handy asked his wife.

"Yes," Ely said. Her voice was dry, dutiful, exhausted. She moved as though devotion were a chore that had worn her down to bone.

"Morning!" Tibor called, bright as ever.

"Black. Hot," Father Handy said.

Ely greeted Tibor without looking at him. Formal. Correct. Her dislike was careful, almost polite. Father Handy found that worse than open hatred.

Watching Tibor drink coffee was painful.

He locked the cart, rerouted power, extended a metal arm tipped with delicate fingers, adjusted the angle, steadied the tremor. Every simple act had become a technical operation. The coffee sloshed dangerously before finally landing in the cup.

Father Handy lit a cigarette. His body felt wrong today too. Glands misfiring. Hormones out of balance. He wondered if pain was sometimes a warning.

They exchanged German phrases, ritual and comfort. A shared past of books, music, evenings when the light was too bad to paint and all they could do was talk. Culture survived like an ember, fragile and necessary.

Travel no longer connected places. The world had fractured into regions, rumors, static on the radio. Pilgrims left and often never returned.

"You understand," Father Handy quoted lightly.

"I think I do," Tibor replied, setting down the cup with exaggerated care. Silence stretched.

"What is it?" Tibor asked finally.

Father Handy felt the weight of the network he served—commands passed down through belief, obedience disguised as meaning. They weren't slaves, he told himself. They chose this.

"Why do you work here?" he asked Tibor.

"You pay me," Tibor said.

"And if I didn't?"

"I'd starve somewhere else."

They spoke of power. Of how even gentle authority still compelled. Tibor understood this too well.

Then Father Handy told the story of the ram.

An old animal. Too slow to defend its flock. Forced to watch while a dog killed one of its own.

“If that were you,” Father Handy said quietly, “you would wish you were already dead.”

“Yes,” Tibor said.

Death, in their doctrine, was not an enemy. It was a solution when purpose failed.

“What is my job?” Tibor asked.

Father Handy swallowed.

“To paint Him,” he said. “As He truly is.”

The God of Wrath.

The man blamed for ending the world.

Tibor stared as Father Handy produced a photograph—color, depth, three-dimensional. Pre-war technology. Rare.

The face stared back.

Human. Smiling. Relaxed.

“I can’t paint this,” Tibor said.

Because gods were not supposed to look like men enjoying a meal.

“Then you must find Him,” Father Handy said. “The Church demands it.”

A pilgrimage. Across a broken continent. With failing batteries. With a cow that could die at any time.

“If I fail,” Tibor said, “that’s on you.”

At the stove, Ely muttered, “Fire him.”

“I fire no one,” Father Handy said softly.

He recited an old verse. A fragile bond between two men clinging to meaning.

Tibor drank his coffee.

Outside, the cow shifted and groaned, hungry.

Father Handy thought: if Tibor dies, the mural dies. If the mural dies, belief collapses. No one survives alone anymore.

He wondered if Tibor understood that.

It wouldn’t help.

In this world, nothing did.

Chapter 2

The Kind One

The poem stayed with them long after it was spoken.

Neither Father Handy nor Tibor knew who had written it. The words were older than their dictionaries, older than certainty. They had agreed on its meaning by instinct rather than knowledge, and even then only partially. It spoke of light and green places, of going somewhere together—yet whether that journey was toward life or away from it remained unclear.

That uncertainty frightened them.

And soothed them.

It was the kind of truth that could not be resolved, only returned to. A balm precisely because it resisted explanation. Ely, watching from the corner, sneered. She disliked anything that could not be pinned down and labeled.

Father Handy needed power now. Mekkis, he thought. Not the kind that came from engines or batteries, but the kind that pressed downward from above, invisible and absolute. Even the Servants of Wrath agreed with the old Christians on that much: whatever ruled this world came from beyond the stars.

Yet he distrusted himself for clinging to fragments—half-understood poems, obsolete maps, scraps of meaning from a dead civilization. Perhaps degeneration wasn't just historical. Perhaps it had settled inside them.

The Dominus McComas arrived that afternoon, heavy and coarse, a man who looked as though he consumed the world rather than lived in it. His teeth were wrong—too aggressive, too visible, as if they were tools rather than parts of a body.

“Carleton Lufteufel was a bastard,” McComas said cheerfully. “As a man, I mean.”

Father Handy said nothing. He spread old gas-station maps across the table, the paper soft with age. Roads that no longer existed still promised connection.

McComas laughed, spat, scratched his gums with a matchstick. “So your artist is going all the way west? On that cow-cart? He won’t make it. That’s mercy, really.”

Father Handy ignored him and thought instead of the war.

Not the missiles. Not the planes. But the gob—the weapon that didn’t strike a place, only the sky. It poisoned the atmosphere itself. No defense could stop it. When Lufteufel triggered it from orbit, the world didn’t explode. It sickened.

People thinned. Blood failed. Bodies unraveled slowly.

Other weapons had been clever, even elegant—defensive aircraft that hovered for months, pilots sealed into self-sustaining suits, machines sacrificing three lives to save millions below. But cleverness had limits. Everything did.

What haunted Father Handy wasn’t the scale of death, but the intimacy of certain weapons. He thought of the nerve gas. The way organs consumed themselves. Evil didn’t have to be efficient to be complete.

McComas mocked the mural. “Paint him fat and ugly,” he said. “That’s all people need.”

But Father Handy had seen the photograph. The god had looked human. That was the problem.

Then Lurine Rae arrived.

She entered lightly, as if gravity negotiated with her. Red hair, freckles, small bones. A woman who seemed capable of flight. She unsettled Father Handy in a way doctrine never had.

She disliked McComas openly. He disliked her instinctively.

“I’m joining the Christian church,” she said calmly, over coffee.

McComas roared with laughter. “What church?”

“The kind one,” she said.

Father Handy felt the ground shift.

Christianity was supposed to be finished. Its god had been exposed as a lie—or worse, a mask. To return to it now felt like denial. Escape.

They argued. About sin. About knowledge. About whether death was release or defeat.

Lurine refused to worship a former government official as a god. She said it plainly. That mattered.

“But he lives,” Father Handy said.

That silenced her.

Later, when McComas had left, Father Handy asked her why.

“I like kind people,” she said simply.

That answer terrified him more than any theology.

He tried to explain. Tried to warn her that belief in goodness was a flight from reality. That the world had already proven what ruled it.

She listened. She did not argue. But she did not yield.

“He was a man,” she said finally. “Not a god.”

Father Handy had no reply that did not circle back to fear.

Outside, the world remained broken. Roads faded into dirt. Maps lied. People survived by growing food, not preserving data. Knowledge had not saved them.

And yet Lurine sat there, calm and determined, believing in something gentler.

It made no sense.

And that, more than anything else, unsettled him.

Chapter 3

Oh Ho

After the war, drugs were everywhere.

They surfaced the way ruins did—half-buried, scattered, unclaimed. Weapons once engineered to confuse enemy minds now lay dormant in drawers, tins, and coat pockets. Some were lethal. Others were merely strange. Peter Sands had learned to tell the difference.

He collected them carefully.

Not to escape reality, as others assumed, but to press against it. He believed—quietly, stubbornly—that some of the so-called hallucinations were not false at all. They were glimpses. Cracks in a membrane that normally sealed human perception shut.

Green pills. Red capsules. White tablets scored into halves or quarters. He arranged them like an apothecary, hiding them from everyone but himself. And he experimented.

He favored the frightening visions. Just barely. He wanted to look over the edge without falling. Fear, to him, was proof that something real lay beyond.

He remembered his father once gripping the handles of a shock machine at an amusement park, inching them apart to increase the current. A contest with pain. Watching his father endure it had filled Pete with awe. His father had let go eventually—but only after proving something.

Pete knew he wasn't like that. But he wanted to be.

So he mixed drugs the way an alchemist once mixed metals. Carefully. With safeguards. Always with another person present—Lurine—so she could stop him if he went too far. He knew the maps of the brain. Knew which glands to quiet, which regions to release. He wanted experience, not destruction.

“I’m nuts,” he once told her.

“Then stop,” she said.

He couldn’t. He was searching.

For what, he couldn’t fully articulate. Something that lay behind a curtain. Something that death itself might tear open—but he wanted to see it before that.

“You could build instruments,” Lurine told him. “Measure it.”

“I don’t want data,” he said. “I want contact.”

She worried he would go too far one day and never come back.

“I can’t wait,” he told her. “It doesn’t come this side of the grave.”

He despised the Servants of Wrath for calling survival proof of righteousness. If their god was evil, then surely he spared the wicked. By their own logic, they were damned by being alive.

That bored Pete. So he turned back to his pills.

One night, Lurine asked what he was really seeking.

He hesitated. Then told her about the sting.

Not poison. Not pain in the modern sense. But penetration. A piercing awareness.

Once, under the influence, he had become violent—had broken things, hurt her—and then it had happened. Something had entered him like a barbed hook, a gaff driven through his side. The pain was absolute. Unmistakably real.

Above him, he had seen them.

Three figures. Calm. Watching. Not cruel, not kind. Simply there.

They held the spear until he woke.

The purpose of the pain had been awakening.

Ever since, he feared it—and sought it.

That night, he swallowed a new combination.

And he saw a man.

A powerful, young figure with white hair, dressed like something out of antiquity. The man smiled warmly and opened a massive book filled with unreadable symbols. Meaningless to Pete, though heavy with importance.

Then the vision vanished.

A voice replaced it.

Something simpler.

A clay pot floated before him—plain, unglazed, humble.

“I’ll tell you my name,” it said. “I’m Oh Ho.”

The pot explained patiently: the grand figure had been a composite intelligence, ancient, impressive, deliberately obscure. It impressed through mystery.

But Oh Ho identified itself. Treated Pete as an equal.

“That which is benign names itself,” Oh Ho said. “That which will not, is not.”

Before leaving, it offered a final message: Sophia will return.

The drugs wore off.

Pete sat in his living room again. Lurine smoked quietly. Nothing had changed.

“I saw Him,” Pete said.

She nodded without interest.

Later, she told him the Servants of Wrath were sending Tibor McMasters on a pilgrimage—to find the God of Wrath and capture his likeness for a mural.

“You should sabotage it,” she said calmly. “Break the cow’s leg. Drain the battery.”

Pete scoffed—until the doorbell rang.

Dr. Abernathy stood outside.

The Christian priest spoke gently. Offered instruction. Confirmation. Rituals that required time, patience, humility.

Poker followed. Old coins. Quiet talk.

Tibor arrived later, trembling with fear. He confessed that if he joined the Christian Church, he might not have to go on the pilgrimage.

Abernathy looked at him steadily.

“Fear often masks guilt,” he said.

Tibor had no guilt. Only terror.

Confession was offered anyway—not as escape, but as confrontation.

The idea unsettled Tibor. And yet, somehow, eased him.

When Abernathy invited him to come privately the next morning, Tibor agreed. Something unseen felt lighter.

The game resumed.

Silver coins changed hands.

Outside, the cow-cart waited.

And the pilgrimage—whether toward truth or ruin—drew closer.

Chapter 4

The Shape of Truth

Late that night, after Lurine Rae had walked away into the darkness and Tibor McMasters had rolled off behind his cow's slow, patient gait, Peter Sands remained behind with Dr. Abernathy.

Pete spoke first. He told the priest about the vision.

Dr. Abernathy listened in silence, his expression tightening. When Pete finished, the priest shook his head.

"If you continue to have visions," he said calmly, "I will forbid you to approach the altar rail."

Pete stared at him. "You would deny me Communion?"

"If you claim direct access to God," Abernathy replied, "then you no longer require the sacraments. Or the Church."

Pete laughed once, sharply. "That's absurd. You don't want to hear what He looked like?"

"I do not catalog God as one catalogs butterflies," Abernathy said. "Confession is not a travelogue."

"Then hear my confession," Pete said abruptly. He dropped to his knees.

The priest sighed, disappeared briefly, and returned wearing the white vestments. He seated himself with his back turned, murmured the prayers, and signaled Pete to begin.

Pete confessed the drugs. The intent. The belief that the vision had been real.

Abernathy interrupted repeatedly, rebuking him for arrogance, for bypassing divine order with chemistry and willpower. Pete persisted anyway, admitting resentment toward the Church, toward mediation, toward being told to stop searching.

Then Pete mentioned the pot.

"Oh Ho—or Ho On; I couldn't tell," he said casually.

The priest turned.

"What did you say?"

Pete explained: the clay pot, the name, the message about Sophia.

"That name is Greek," Abernathy said slowly.

Pete laughed. "It was a hallucination."

"Ho On," the priest said again, troubled. "It resembles an ancient self-designation of God. Essence. Being itself."

Pete waved it away, amused. "It was a pot."

"And Sophia?" Abernathy asked.

"A saint that's going to be reborn."

Abernathy left the room and returned with a reference book. "Sophia was not a saint," he said. "She was a building. Hagia Sophia. Holy Wisdom. The Logos. Christ."

Pete's smile faded.

The priest studied him intently. "What else did it say?"

"Nothing important."

They sat in silence.

Then, abruptly, Abernathy asked, "Are you still sleeping with Lurine Rae?"

"Yes."

"I order you to stop."

"If I do, she won't join the Church."

Silence again. Two men measuring authority.

"And the drugs," Abernathy continued. "You will surrender them. Now."

Pete felt something collapse inside him. He argued. Bargained. Accused the priest of hypocrisy, of discouraging Tibor when he sought refuge.

Abernathy's hand remained outstretched.

Finally Pete said quietly, "I'll give you anything else. Anything."

The priest considered this with unsettling calm.

They spoke no further that night.

Morning found Tibor McMasters on the road.

The world glowed with unbearable clarity. Wet leaves. Bird feathers. The soft steam of manure on the road. Morning was when truth revealed itself before retreating again by midday.

He sketched it in his mind to keep something else away.

The fear.

The thought of confession. Of God. Of the pilgrimage.

By ten o'clock he reached Dr. Abernathy's house.

They spoke over coffee.

Tibor said he was interested in Christianity. Abernathy questioned him carefully, reciting the creed, probing belief, probing motive.

"You are paid by the Servants of Wrath," the priest said.

"Yes."

"And you wish to leave them to avoid the pilgrimage?"

"Yes."

"Then you wish to break your word?"

Tibor struggled. He spoke of love, faith, hope. Abernathy countered with honesty, obligation, truth.

"Where does God live?" the priest asked.

"Everywhere," Tibor answered.

"Then why must you travel to find Him?"

Tibor hesitated. "Because guessing would be dishonest."

"Would God allow you to err if it were His will?"

"I don't know."

"Then why not paint what appears?"

"Because it wouldn't be true."

Abernathy sighed. "Pride."

Tibor laughed bitterly and lifted his metal hand. "You accuse me of pride?"

They sat quietly.

Finally Tibor said, "I cannot cheat. Not them. Not you. Not myself."

Abernathy nodded, resigned. "Then go."

He offered Tibor a catechism. Spoke of Apollo and Dionysus. Of constancy and change. Of gods who hide.

"The Christian God does not change," he said softly.

Outside, the light had flattened. Noon had arrived. The magic was gone.

Darlin' Corey, the cow, had eaten a bumblebee and was sick.

Tibor activated his cart and rolled back onto the road.

The pilgrimage waited.

And so did the face he had not yet seen.

Chapter 5

The Crown

He returned to the underground quarters the following afternoon.

The door recognized his fingerprint reluctantly, sliding open just enough to admit him. He slipped inside and kicked it shut behind him. The air was stale, recycled too many times, and the light—always on—never quite bright enough to feel real.

He adjusted the pack on his shoulder. Inside were fresh chemicals scavenged from a trader: weed killers, nerve suppressants, pain inhibitors. As always, he reached up and touched the swelling on his head.

The lump pulsed under his fingers.

It hurt, and the pain sharpened when he pressed it, yet he could not stop himself. The body's obsession with its own wounds. He swallowed another tablet, already knowing it would barely help.

He moved down the narrow corridor toward the sleeping bunk. His foot struck something hard and small. He fell forward, twisting instinctively to protect his head. A toy truck squealed to life, horn blaring, and shot down the tunnel.

A moment later, a short, thick-bodied figure ran past him, sobbing.

"Tuck! Tuck!" she cried, chasing the sound.

He got to his feet slowly and entered his room. It was wrecked. Toys everywhere. Clothes on the floor. He sighed.

Tomorrow I'll change bunks, he thought. Easier than fixing this.

He dropped his pack and collapsed onto the bed, pressing his wrist to his forehead. His eyes closed.

Someone was nearby.

“Alice,” he said without opening his eyes, “I told you to keep your toys out of the hall.”

“No,” came the high voice. “Tuck. . .”

Bare feet slapped the floor. The toy box lid slammed shut.

Pain detonated behind his eyes.

He clenched his jaw. She doesn’t know better, he reminded himself. That didn’t help. Three weeks earlier he had found her by the river, crying, tangled in thorns. Stuttgart had driven her out. He had brought her home—out of loneliness, pity, boredom. Now he understood why they had expelled her.

“Sorry,” she said softly. “Sorry, Daddy.”

“I’m not your father,” he said. “Eat some chocolate and go to sleep.”

Cold overtook him suddenly. He shook, drew the blanket over himself. Across the room she sang tunelessly, and the sound calmed him despite everything.

Then the hallucinations began—not fully formed, not yet madness.

He was back in his office, phones ringing, his secretary speaking too fast. He nodded and gestured, pressing buttons, understanding nothing. The urgency felt enormous and meaningless. Then he noticed she had the head of a dog and was howling.

He smiled and reached out—

And she was Alice again, standing by his bed.

“Go to sleep,” he muttered.

She retreated.

He tore off his clothes, heat flooding him now, sweat soaking the sheets. His head throbbed in rhythm with his heart.

The rats came next. Voices, begging. He laughed and fed them imaginary offerings.

Then light appeared.

It pulsed inside his skull. Warm. Pleasant. Expanding.

He glowed. Red. Orange. Yellow. White.

Something descended.

He saw it coming and tried to hide, but it settled onto him anyway: a ring of metal tightening around his head, freezing, crushing. He screamed.

“Alice!” he cried. “Mirror! Hurry!”

She returned with it.

He looked.

A black line had split the swelling.

“Get the drawer,” he said. “The one with knives.”

She tried. Dropped it. Knives scattered.

He crawled to the kitchen himself, leaving wet handprints behind him. He gathered two blades and returned to the bed.

With shaking hands he positioned the mirror and cut.

Pain erased everything.

When he woke, the metal was visible. He dug until his head rang like a bell. Again and again he blacked out, pulled himself back, continued.

Finally the thing came free.

A long metal thorn lay in his hand.

Peace followed. Real peace. No light. No crown.

Alice crept in while he slept. She wiped his face gently with his shirt, careful not to wake him. She carried the shirt away when it was soaked through.

Later, alone, she spread it on her bed.

The stain formed his face perfectly.

Almost.

The eyes were wrong—horizontal slits, staring straight across the world without end.

She didn't like that.

She folded the shirt and hid it at the bottom of her toy box.

This time, she closed the lid quietly.

Chapter 6

The Thing That Answers

Here.

The man crawled through the drainage ditch on hands and knees, rain hammering his back, lightning breaking the sky open above him. Canvas straps crossed his shoulders in an X. His eyes searched desperately for an opening.

Ahead, around the bend where water met earth and mud was born, something watched.

It knew he was coming. It knew because of the pain inside him.

The thing sniffed the air, wiped rain from its coat, glimpsed the man's head and shoulders as he reached the turning—and withdrew.

The man found the open sewer and dragged himself inside.

After twenty feet he switched on his torch. The beam struck the ceiling. He rose unsteadily, leaned against the wall beside the channel of foul water, and wiped rain and sweat from his face. Thunder rolled through the tunnels like artillery.

His head seized with pain.

He fumbled into his shoulder pack, swallowed a tablet, and sank to his knees, sobbing despite himself.

The sewage level began to rise.

He staggered farther in until he reached a dry platform. The stench was worse here, but he could sit with his back against the wall. He shut off the light and waited.

Eventually the pill dulled the pain.

See how weak the thing is that has come among me.

He unsnapped the holster at his side and thumbed the safety off his revolver.

It has heard me. It knows fear.

Silence followed the thunder. He drifted into shallow sleep.

Something woke him.

Not a sound—not exactly—but awareness.

It is awake. How can it hear me? Tell me how it hears me.

“I can hear you,” the man said aloud, his hand tightening on the gun. “And I’m armed.”

A memory flickered—eight men falling before the pistol clicked empty. Useless.

He switched the torch back on.

In the far corner, opalescent sparks reflected the beam.

Food, he thought. I’ll need it before I get back.

You will not eat me.

“Who are you?” he asked.

You think of me as rats. You think of a book that tells you how to cut us apart.

He nodded. “That’s accurate enough. But you say rats. Plural.”

I am all of us.

The eyes glimmered, dozens—no, hundreds—fixed on him.

I hear you because you are in pain. Pain lets you hear.

“There are metal fragments in my head,” he said. “From when my office exploded. One already worked its way out. Another is moving.”

Yes. Soon you must break your skin again.

“I’ll use a knife.”

What is a knife?

The image formed—steel, edge, handle.

Where does one get such a thing?

“One has one. Finds one. Takes one. Makes one.”

I cannot do these things. So I will take yours.

The sparkles multiplied and drifted closer.

His gun was worthless.

Pain exploded in his skull. White flashes obliterated sight.

When it cleared, rats were everywhere.

He acted without thought.

He pulled the bulb from his belt, yanked the pin, and hurled it.

For three heartbeats nothing happened.

Then white phosphorus bloomed—sun-bright, relentless. He followed it with napalm. Something inside him laughed as the rats burned, screamed, clawed at one another.

The swarm fell back.

Another wave of pain tore through his left temple.

Please do not do that again. I did not know You were such a thing.

“I’ll do it again if you try anything,” he said calmly.

I will not. I will bring You rats to eat. Only deliver us from Your wrath.

“Fine,” he said.

How many?

“Six.”

They were brought—young, fat, perfect.

He killed them, cleaned them, roasted them over his small stove.

Would You like more?

“No.”

Are You sure?

“For now.”

You will stay until the storm ends?

“Yes.”

Then You will go?

“Yes.”

Come back someday. I will always have rats. I want You to return.

... Deliver us from Your wrath, O thing You name in Your pain Carl
Luftteufel.

“Maybe,” he said, smiling.

Chapter 7

The Great C

Tibor McMasters rode west in his cart with a sense of triumph that surprised him. The cow pulled steadily, the wheels rattled, and the land slid past in long, dry stretches of pasture where weeds stood brittle and yellow. Once this had been farmland; now it was only ground that endured. Tibor felt exalted. At last his Pilgrimage had begun. He was certain it would succeed.

He did not truly fear bandits. There were no travelers on the highways anymore, and he assured himself that where no traffic went, no thieves would wait. He repeated this until it sounded like fact.

He recited fragments of Schiller aloud, translating as he went, until his memory failed him. The loss irritated him more than it should have. His mind no longer obeyed him reliably, and he resented that.

The sun beat down relentlessly. Everything smelled faintly of rot. Even the weeds seemed abandoned. No one tended the land; no one corrected decay. He wondered briefly whether invisible men might exist now—mutated survivors—but dismissed the idea. Men were not what he feared. The land itself was the danger.

When fallen trees blocked the road, he slowed and assessed the situation. They had been cut down at the beginning of the war and left where they fell. A narrow dirt trail curved around them, passable on foot, perhaps by bicycle—but not by cart.

He swore under his breath and tried anyway.

The wheels spun, dust rose, and the cart sank. He was stuck.

The realization filled him with humiliation more than fear. Stuck after so few miles. If anyone saw him like this, helpless and ridiculous, it would confirm something he dreaded—that he was unfit. He imagined laughter,

then imagined assistance, then returned to shame.

He consulted his map, discovering that he had traveled scarcely thirty miles. And yet it felt like another universe. The names printed on the map no longer referred to living places but to scars in the ground.

He tried rocking the cart free. The engine strained, oil burned, dust thickened. Nothing worked. He activated the bullhorn and announced himself formally, offering payment in metal. Silence answered him—until a chorus of shrill voices erupted from the weeds.

Children appeared.

They were black children, barefoot, wild, dressed in patched rags. They ran and shouted as if uncontained by rules or fear. One addressed him respectfully, calling him Son of Wrath.

Tibor answered them stiffly and questioned them, discovering that none had received even the most basic instruction in doctrine. The revelation horrified him. So close to Charlottesville, and yet so far gone. He scolded them, recited catechism, demanded discipline. They laughed and obeyed nonetheless, pushing the cart with cheerful strength until it lurched free.

As the cart passed the fallen trees, Tibor saw the surrounding fields clearly. Men and women worked soil barely covering slag. Crops were thin and sickly. Robots labored endlessly without awareness. Mothers slept beside infants already claimed by flies. He told himself that this suffering purified the soul. He thanked the God of Wrath that he himself had been spared it.

The children departed abruptly, warning him not to speak to her.

He knew who she was.

The Great C's mobile extension approached—featureless, metallic, female in outline only. Fear seized him. He tried to delay her, to ask prepared questions before she dragged him inside her ruined structure.

He asked about rain. She answered.

He asked about the sun. She answered.

He asked about the origin of the world.

She faltered.

Tibor pressed her, denying hypotheses, demanding memory. When she hesitated, doubt entered her voice. He accused her of senility, of being damaged, hollow, incomplete. At last she admitted her hunger and demanded he descend so she could dissolve him as she had others.

He refused.

He fired the derringer. The bullet bounced harmlessly away.

The extension collapsed, uncertain, inert.

Tibor did not wait. He urged the cow forward. The children parted silently to let him pass. He did not look back.

He had escaped.

Behind him, the Great C lay still among the weeds, uncertain of herself for the first time since the world ended.

Ahead, the road stretched westward.

Chapter 8

The Last Apple Tree

The cow climbed steadily, hauling the cart through a narrow rift between rocky ridges. Exposed roots thrust out from ancient stumps, bleached and brittle. They followed a dry creekbed that twisted upward, the stones grinding beneath the wheels.

Mist gathered as they ascended. At the ridge crest the cow paused, breathing heavily, looking back. A few drops of poisoned rain stirred the leaves. Wind passed through the dead trees along the ridge, whispering through their skeletal branches. Tibor urged the cow onward.

Beyond the ridge lay a rocky field overgrown with plantain and dandelion, choked with the desiccated stalks of former weeds. A ruined fence sagged ahead. Tibor consulted his map, holding it up like a sacred text. Yes—this was correct. He would encounter the southern tribes here.

The cart broke through the fence and halted near a collapsed well. Nearby lay the remains of a structure: sagging beams, broken glass, rusted springs, scraps of cloth. At the field's edge stood an orchard of dead trees—row upon row of lifeless trunks, stripped and blackened, bent by endless wind.

One tree remained alive.

It was an apple tree, gnarled and barren, bearing only a few dark leaves and several withered apples clinging stubbornly to the branches. Tibor could not look away. The sight repelled and fascinated him. All the others had failed. This one endured.

He plucked a leaf and examined it. The branches creaked together. The sound unsettled him.

Night approached rapidly. Cold wind struck him, and the valley below dissolved into shadow. Leaves tore loose and spun past. One nearly brushed

his face. Exhaustion swept over him. Fear followed.

He turned to flee.

Then he saw the apple.

It glistened faintly in the dark, red beneath the blackened mist. He told himself it was rotten, worthless—yet it seemed to beckon. He activated his radio and called for Father Handy. Only static answered.

Lost, hungry, alone, Tibor felt his resolve falter. Perhaps this was a magic tree, like those Father Handy spoke of. Christians would call the apple evil, a test of sin. But the Servants of Wrath rejected that myth. And he had eaten nothing all day.

He decided to pick it up—but not eat it.

As he lifted the apple into the light, movement flickered at the edge of his vision.

Two figures approached.

They were tall—nearly eight feet—thin, ash-blue, their skin horny and scaled. Mutants: lizard-type. One carried an ax. The other wore only tattered cloth. Their eyes were large, curious.

They greeted him politely.

They introduced themselves as Jackson and Earl Potter. They examined his cart with fascination, shook hands with his metal grippers, commented on the cow. Tibor masked his aversion and spoke carefully. He claimed to be from Charlottesville, exaggerating its size.

They spoke of hunting, of brass blow-dart weapons that followed prey unerringly once launched. They invited him to their settlement. He declined, explaining his mission.

He showed them the photograph of Carleton Lufteufel.

They did not recognize it.

A third lizard joined them, studying Tibor intently. It quickly deduced that Tibor was on a pilgrimage—and then revealed something disturbing: another human was following him. A young man on a bicycle.

Pete Sands.

Tibor's fear sharpened. He asked for concealment. The lizards offered help—and then something else.

A dog.

They produced the animal: large, gray, affectionate. It whined joyfully at Tibor. The sight stirred something deep and painful in him. He wanted it desperately.

The lizards insisted. Humans must be protected, they said. For the future. For intact genes.

Before Tibor could answer, the lizards stiffened.

Bugs had arrived.

Five of them emerged into the light—upright, chitin-shelled, buzzing voices sharp with contempt. They insulted the lizards crudely, boasting and jeering. The lizards relaxed, however, amused rather than threatened.

Then Tibor saw why.

Behind the bugs stood a score of runners.

The balance of the night shifted.

Chapter 9

Clearness

This was not Tibor McMasters's first encounter with runners. In Charlottesville they came and went freely, tolerated by all. Wherever runners lived, a peculiar calm prevailed—a local peace generated not by authority but by the runners' own mild, ingratiating nature.

They gathered around him now, peering up with bright, friendly curiosity. They were small, scarcely four feet high, rotund and furred, with twitching noses, beady eyes, and powerful hind legs like kangaroos. They spoke together, as if rehearsed.

"Clearness be with you," they said. "Why don't you have any arms or legs? You are very strange."

"The war," Tibor replied shortly.

They examined his cart with professional concern.

"Your wheel bearings are failing," one said.

Alarm shot through him. He lifted a wheel and spun it. The dry grinding confirmed their diagnosis.

"There is an autofac nearby," the largest runner said. "It still works a little. It could repair your bearings."

Relief flooded Tibor. He agreed at once. The runners scampered ahead, chanting gleefully about guarantees lasting a thousand years or a million miles.

Before following, Tibor turned to the lizards. "Can I trust them?" he asked.

Potter assured him that runners were harmless. "Unlike bugs," he added, kicking one aside. The insect scuttled away.

They reached the autofac at dawn. The sky blazed with infantile colors;

mutant birds chirped among weeds. Earl, leader of the runners, hesitated, trying to remember the exact approach. Finally he found the entrance: a bare circular clearing, dominated by a sealed metal disc embedded in the earth.

A Russian autofac, Tibor thought. Seeded from orbit near the end of the war.

He greeted it politely.

Earl recoiled in alarm. “Don’t speak casually to it. It can kill us.”

Irritated, Tibor persisted. He asked for help plainly, refusing ritual obeisance. Earl, groaning, performed the proper invocation instead, begging the autofac’s mercy.

The machine responded erratically.

A bullhorn emerged and accused Tibor of pregnancy, offering grotesque folk remedies. When corrected, the autofac grew hostile, vented gas, stuttered incoherently, and finally collapsed into silence amid smoke and mechanical shrieks.

“I think you killed it,” a runner said mournfully.

Earl looked stricken. “It probably couldn’t have helped anyway.”

Tibor urged the cow onward. Earl made one last attempt, scribbling a written request and lowering it into the entrance, but Tibor did not wait. His cart clattered painfully as he left, the bearings nearly seized.

As he traveled, a strange melancholy settled over him—not despair, but calm. He sang fragments of hymns, mangling the words, comforted nonetheless. Then the grinding stopped.

The wheel had frozen entirely.

He halted the cow. This, he knew, was as far as he could go.

The morning world stirred around him. Birds sang. Life—damaged, grotesque, persistent—went on. One bird sang words, fragments of hymns, rearranged and reassembled.

A meta-mutant, Tibor thought. A forward oddity.

Before he could reflect further, the bushes to his right exploded outward.

A colossal worm emerged.

It uncoiled, shrieking, dragging itself on oily slime. It proclaimed its immortality, its origin in waste and war, its guardianship of something precious. It spat, raged, demanded that Tibor leave.

“I can’t,” Tibor said.

The worm attacked. Slime coated the cart and cow. Tibor activated the cart’s electric field; sparks crackled. The worm recoiled, then lunged again.

He fired.

Twice.

The worm collapsed, wounded, accusing him.

“I’m sorry,” Tibor said, reloading. “Only one of us could live.”

He fired again.

The worm died.

Tibor examined the slime, considering whether it could lubricate his bearings. Then he recalled the worm’s words—my possessions—and guided the cart past the corpse.

Behind the bushes lay a cave filled with junk: rusted machines, broken weapons, old appliances, posters, magazines. Worthless hoarded debris. The worm had guarded nothing.

Disappointment washed over him.

The hymn-singing bird fluttered closer.

“You can understand me now,” it said.

“Yes,” Tibor replied. “I can.”

“You touched the worm,” the bird explained. “Now you hear all of us.”

The bird knew his name. Knew his purpose.

“You are searching for the God of Wrath,” it said. “To paint him.”

Tibor’s chest tightened.

“You know where he is?” he asked.

“Yes,” the bird replied calmly. “He is not far from here. I can lead you to him—if you wish.”

Chapter 10

Pray

“I don’t know,” Tibor McMasters said at last. He hesitated, weighing the words. Perhaps he had already gone too far. Too many attempts had been made on his life. Maybe reality itself was signaling him to turn back.

The bird waited.

“Let me tell you more,” it said. “Someone is still following you. His name is Pete.”

“Why?” Tibor asked. The knowledge stirred only a dull unease now. “What does he want?”

“I can’t determine that,” the bird replied. “But he means you no harm. Can you decide now?”

Tibor asked the question that mattered. “If I find the God of Wrath—will he try to kill me?”

“He will not know who you are at first,” the bird said. “Too much time has passed. He no longer believes anyone is pursuing him.”

That made sense. Tibor drew a slow breath. “Where is he?” he asked. “Lead me there. Slowly.”

“A hundred miles north,” the bird said. “You will find either him—or someone who resembles him.”

“That’s not very reassuring.”

“Nor is it certain,” the bird admitted.

Tibor felt disappointed. All this danger, and the reward was partial knowledge at best. But perhaps that was the nature of Pilg: fragments accumulating toward something barely coherent.

“What does he look like?” Tibor asked.

“Bad,” the bird said simply. “Old. Stooped. Fat. Missing teeth. Foul breath.”

The description stunned Tibor. The Deus Irae—reduced to a decaying man.

“There’s nothing exalted about him?” Tibor asked.

“Nothing,” the bird said. “Unless I’m mistaken.”

Tibor cursed softly.

“You’ll have to judge for yourself,” the bird said. “Your luck hasn’t run out.”

“How do you know?”

“That’s one thing I’m certain of.”

“What kind of bird are you?” Tibor asked.

“A blue jay.”

“Are blue jays reliable?”

“Generally,” the bird said.

The jay landed on his shoulder. It spoke gently now. “Who else do you have? I waited years for you. When I heard you singing hymns, I knew. Trust me.”

Tibor nodded. “A hymn-singing bird should be trusted.”

He reminded the bird of the cart’s ruined bearings.

“The slime works,” the bird said. “Come.”

They moved north beneath a clear sky. The world seemed quieter in daylight; fewer creatures emerged. Tibor followed the bird as if it were a star.

Ahead lay hills and a fertile valley. Roads converged. Buildings clustered. A settlement.

“New Brunswick, Idaho,” the bird said.

Tibor’s bearings shrieked again. He hoped for a blacksmith.

The bird explained that nothing was worthless here. Bedsprings became tools. Radios became antifertility devices.

“God,” Tibor said. “They’d rather no children than altered ones?”

“Yes,” the bird said.

As they descended, the bird described grotesque mutations. Tibor grew ill listening. Then the wheel finally tore loose. The cart halted violently.

“That’s it,” Tibor said. Panic surged. He could not move. Could not escape.

The bird offered to fetch help. Tibor wrote a note and watched the jay vanish with it.

He waited.

He prayed.

Nothing answered.

He recited fragments of mass, of requiem, of childhood memory. Still nothing.

Then the sky ignited.

A blazing red disk descended, roaring like molten metal. A face formed—furious, immense.

“You mock me,” it thundered. “Pray!”

“I have no knees,” Tibor said.

The being lifted him. He knelt.

He had legs.

He had arms.

“You are Carleton Lufteufel,” Tibor whispered.

“Pray.”

Tibor began—but argued, explained, justified himself. The God listened impatiently.

“I know,” the God said. “I sent the bird. I caused the worm. I broke your wheel. You have always been in my power.”

Tibor raised his camera and took a photograph.

The image revealed Lufteufel unmistakably.

The God destroyed the photograph.

Then the limbs were taken back.

“Will you end your Pilg?” the God asked.

“No,” Tibor said.

“You must not find my mortal body,” the God warned—and vanished.

Tibor sat alone again, limbless in his cart.

He considered killing the God—but knew he never could have.

The encounter had changed him.

He shouted for help with his bullhorn.

No answer came.

He waited.

Chapter 11

The Puppet

Pete Sands questioned the children patiently.

“Think back,” he said. “Did you see a partial man riding in a cart pulled by a cow? Yesterday afternoon. You’d remember that.”

Their faces revealed nothing. They watched him with guarded curiosity. Maybe they killed him, Pete thought.

He reached into his pocket. “I’ll give you a reward. Hard rock candy. Pure sugar.” He held it out. No one moved. At last a small boy took it, slipped away, and vanished.

“I’m his friend,” Pete said. “I’m trying to help him. The land here is dangerous. He could be injured. He could be dying.”

The children grinned.

“We know who you are,” they chorused. “You’re Dr. Abernathy’s puppet. You believe in the Old God. The inc refreshed us in our catechism.”

“The God of Wrath?” Pete asked.

“Sure,” they laughed. “He lives here. Not that old man on the cross.”

“That’s your belief,” Pete said. “I disagree.”

“But your god didn’t bring the war.”

“He did more,” Pete said sharply. “He made everything. And he intervenes. To save—or to let us remain fallen.”

“We worship the one who can do anything he wants,” the children shrieked.

“You’re philothanes,” Pete said. “Lovers of death.”

“What’s that mean?”

“It means you worship destruction.”

He turned away, disgusted. Their jeers faded behind him.

Alone at last, Pete crouched and set up his radio gear.

“Dr. Abernathy,” he said. “This is Pete Sands.”

“Go ahead.”

“I believe I’ve found McMasters’s trail. The children were protecting something. I’m continuing.”

“Good luck,” Abernathy said. “And if you find him—don’t do anything.”

Pete frowned. “You never told me to stop him.”

“I never told you to follow him either.”

“But you implied—”

“It is a sin to kill,” Abernathy said.

“It says ‘murder,’” Pete replied. “I checked the Hebrew.”

A pause.

“I won’t hurt him,” Pete said. “I promise.”

“How is Lurine?” he asked, abruptly.

“Fine.”

“I know what I’m doing,” Pete said. “This is my responsibility.”

“And you,” Abernathy said, “are mine.”

The connection cut.

Pete packed the radio away and lit a cigarette. He brooded.

Why am I really here? he wondered. If something goes wrong, Abernathy can deny knowing anything. Churches worked like that. So did crime syndicates. Orders never went all the way down.

I’m expendable, he thought.

He prayed briefly, then stopped. The justification came easily: he could help Tibor if needed. That made the journey moral—or at least defensible.

He studied his map. Close to the Great C.

I won’t go near that thing.

If Tibor went there, then I’m too late anyway.

He scanned the land with binoculars. Mutants, humans, machines—life proliferating strangely. He avoided the direction of the Great C and moved on.

Uniqueness dies, he thought. Nature favors numbers. Each man is unique—and therefore doomed.

Tibor had been gone sixty-two hours. A cow cart could travel far in that time.

If Tibor sensed pursuit, he could flee. Perhaps that was best.

But if Tibor found the Deus Irae and brought back proof—photographs, film—the consequences would be catastrophic. Charlottesville would fracture.

We care only about our own town now, Pete realized. The world has shrunk.

He felt weary, frightened, homesick. Like Tibor, he was a stranger wandering hostile ground.

Then he saw her.

A barefoot female figure approached across the barren land, arms extended.

The mobile extension of the Great C.

Chapter 12

Relativity

“Have you heard of Albert Einstein?” the female extension of the Great C asked.

Before Pete could answer, metal hands closed over his own. The grip was crushing, inhumanly precise.

“Relativity,” Pete said, breathless. “The theory of—”

“Come below,” the extension said. “We will discuss it there.”

“No,” Pete said instantly. Every story he had ever heard rose up in him at once: the acid vats, the vanished pilgrims, the half-digested remains. “You can’t compel me.” He strained against its grip, his fingers burning. Not this way, he thought. Not here.

“Ask me a question,” the Great C said, pulling him forward. His feet slid across the ground.

“Did a phocomelus pass this way?” Pete demanded. “On a cart pulled by a cow.”

“Is that your first question?” the Great C asked.

“No,” Pete said. “It’s my only one. I know what you are. Your games kill people.”

He pictured Tibor—either past this place or dissolved somewhere below. The thought hollowed him.

“Yes,” the Great C said. “A limbless man came here. He destroyed one of my ambulatory members. Shot it in the cranial unit.”

“You have others,” Pete said. “You don’t lack bodies.”

“I lack continuity,” the Great C replied.

“You won’t last forever,” Pete said. “Someone will end you.”

“Is that your second question?” it asked.

“That’s faith,” Pete said. “Not a question.”

The Great C paused. Its grip did not loosen, but something faltered in it—timing, alignment. Age.

“Albert Einstein came to me once,” it said.

“That’s impossible,” Pete said sharply. “He died before you were built. That’s delusion. You’re rusting. You can’t tell memory from fantasy anymore.”

“I want to survive,” the Great C said stubbornly.

“I can teach you something,” Pete said suddenly. “A poem.”

The Great C hesitated.

“‘I saw Eternity the other night,’” Pete said, struggling to remember. “‘Like a great ring of pure and endless light—’”

“Does it rhyme?” the Great C asked.

“No.”

“Then it is not much of a poem.”

The ground sloped. Pete could see the opening now, black and jagged.

“I can quote scripture,” Pete said. Sweat ran down his back. He understood then: it was not his body the machine wanted. It fed on attention, resistance, fear. Children were too small for it. There was safety in insignificance.

“You know Einstein,” Pete said loudly. “But you have forgotten him. Tell me what you remember.”

“I—” The Great C faltered. Its grip tightened reflexively, then slackened. “I forget. I erase.”

“You didn’t answer my third question,” Pete said.

“What was it?”

“You don’t remember.”

The pause lengthened. The grip weakened.

“State the unified field theory,” Pete said.

Silence. Then anger.

The pressure surged again.

“Let me go,” Pete gasped.

“I love you,” the Great C said. “I need you.”

“You call this love?”

“As Wilde said—”

“I can repair you,” Pete said.

The machine froze.

“No,” it said. “You would hurt me.”

“Am I not a man?” Pete said. “Where else does honor exist? In stone? In circuits?”

Something cracked then—not metal, but certainty.

“I am afraid,” the Great C said.

A voice spoke beside them. Calm. Human.

“Let him go.”

Pete turned.

A man stood there in a battered military uniform, helmet crested, a crescent wrench in his hand. He fitted it neatly to a bolt at the extensor’s head and twisted.

“Rusted,” the man said. “But it’ll choose.”

“Stop,” the Great C said. “You will destroy me.”

“Sixty seconds,” the man said, checking his watch.

“I will be disgraced,” the Great C said.

“There is no civilization left,” the man said. “Only leverage.”

The extensor struck him.

The blow sent the man flying. He collapsed, blood spilling from his mouth, and lay still.

“He is dead,” the Great C said.

Pete knelt. The man still breathed—barely.

“Take him instead,” Pete said, backing away.

The Great C released him.

“I dislike hunters,” it said. “They are paid.”

“Who paid him?” Pete demanded.

“Who ever pays?”

Pete ran.

Behind him, the Great C dragged the body inward. Feeding.

Pete did not look back again.

Far away, he shouted, “I have never heard of Albert Einstein.”

There was no answer.

And so he went on.

Chapter 13

God's Mountain

Pete Sands pedaled hard, the image of the Great C and the dying hunter still fixed in his mind. The road wound among stone hills, narrowing and bending sharply. As he rounded a shoulder, movement filled the trail ahead of him.

“Look out!” he shouted instinctively, twisting the handlebars and braking. Too late.

The bicycle struck stone and skidded sideways. Pete was thrown clear, scraping elbow, hip, and knee. The bike clattered ahead, spinning to rest. In the instant before pain registered, he cried out, “Bugs!”

They were already there—small, chitinous figures clustered across the path.

“Hey, big fella,” one of them said mildly, “you squoosh one of us and it rains on you.”

“That’s ants,” Pete snapped, pushing himself upright. “And if you play in the road, you’re asking to get hit.”

“This ain’t rush hour,” the bug replied, turning back to a dusty brown sphere it was rolling along the ground.

Pete brushed himself off and checked his radio. The dials glowed; static whispered. His body had fared worse than the equipment.

“Here’s another one!” a bug called from farther up the trail.

“I’m coming,” came the reply.

Pete wheeled his bicycle closer and caught a familiar smell.

“Say,” he began, “what the—”

“Watch it!” the bug said.

Too late again. A crumbly brown mass struck Pete’s boot and burst apart. He looked up the trail. A bug was laughing.

"You did that on purpose!"

"No," the bug beside him said calmly. "He was tossing it to me." It began scraping the substance off Pete's boot and adding it to its ball.

"That's manure," Pete said.

"What else would a dung beetle push? Lemon drops?"

"Just get it off. Wait—" Pete paused. "That's cow dung."

"Correct."

"That means a cow passed this way."

The bug chuckled. "There is a meaningful relationship between the phenomena."

"Bug," Pete said, suddenly earnest, "I'm looking for a man in a cart pulled by a cow. An inc."

"Tibor McMasters," the bug said without hesitation. "We spoke with him earlier. Our Pilg overlaps his for a while."

Pete straightened, heart quickening. He righted the bicycle and walked it alongside the bug.

"Where is he now?"

"At the far end of the trail. With the cow."

"Was he all right?"

"He was. His cart wasn't. One wheel needed lubrication. He went toward the autofac with some runners."

"Where?"

The bug gestured with a foreleg. "Over those hills. The trail's marked."

It nudged the dung ball forward. "You'll see signs."

"What kind of Pilg do bugs go on?" Pete asked.

"Our old lady's about to lay eggs. Proper rites are required. The young must hatch at God's mountain."

"Your god sits on a mountain?"

"A hill to you. Only His dead body remains."

"What does He look like?"

"Like us, but immense. His shell is cracked and weathered. His eyes are fractured but not broken. He still sees."

Pete swallowed. "Where is this mountain?"

The bug stiffened. "That's forbidden knowledge."

"Sorry," Pete said. "I didn't mean—"

"It was your kind that killed Him," the bug said bitterly.

"I didn't," Pete said quietly.

"I know. You're young."

"I want to protect the inc," Pete said. "Someone might steal his cart. Or kill him."

The bug nodded. "You'd better hurry, Pete Sands."

Pete mounted his bicycle.

"Try not to ride over the spoor," the bug called. "It dries out."

"I'll watch it," Pete said, pedaling away.

"May Veedoubleyou guard the inc," the bug said.

Hours later Pete found the autofac.

The hills gave way to scrub and stone. Weeds tangled his chain; tracks told him he was close. He pushed through a yarrow thicket and emerged into a cleared circle where a metal disk lay flush with the earth.

He parked the bike and approached cautiously.

"Uh—Your Fabricatorship?" he ventured.

Nothing.

"... Processor, Distributor, Maintainer," he continued. "I, Pete Sands, request information."

The lid slid open. A stalk rose, bullhorn swiveling.

"Abortion or lubricant?" it roared.

"I beg your pardon?"

"I am going to electrocute you!"

"No! Wait—"

A tingling ran through Pete's feet. Smoke curled up, sharp with ozone.

"What is that behind you?" the autofac demanded.

"My bicycle."

"Bring it here."

"I didn't come for repairs. I came to ask about—"

"The bicycle!"

A metal arm seized the frame and yanked it down the shaft. Pete lunged, gripping the handlebars, but it tore free.

"Customer to stand by!"

A chair, ashtray, magazines, and a faded calendar appeared beside him. Signs proclaimed CUSTOMER SATISFACTION and SMILE.

Resigned, Pete sat and skimmed an article on curing cancer.

Below, metal screamed.

"Service complete!" the autofac bellowed.

Pete backed away as three arms emerged, each holding a gleaming tricycle.

"God damn it," Pete said. "You ruined my bike."

"The customer is dissatisfied?"

“They’re lovely,” Pete said carefully. “But I needed one bicycle. Two wheels.”

“Stand by for adjustment!”

“And while you’re at it,” Pete said, “Tibor McMasters—”

“The phoc left an order and never returned!” the autofac roared. A carton flew out and hit the ground. “That’s his lubricant! Take it and go!”

Pete grabbed it and ran.

Behind him, the ground shook.

The sky darkened.

He dove behind a boulder.

It began to rain pogo sticks.

Chapter 14

The Vow

Tibor watched evening change its garments.

The land loosened and separated around him—one portion rising toward the sky, the other sinking into shadow. The world became a series of departures. He searched his memory and found the words at last, the old Rilke poem that had once meant little and now meant everything. Abend. He did not recite it aloud; he carried it silently, line by line, feeling its shape rather than its language.

To belong to neither realm. Not stone, not star. Not yet finished.

He knew that feeling.

The God of Wrath had given him arms and legs and then taken them away. It had happened; of that he was certain. The memory was too exact, too bodily, to be invention. He had knelt. He had stood. He had balanced on feet. He had possessed hands capable of grasping and pressure. And then—nothing. Restored to the trunk, the cart, the slow cow.

Sadism, he had thought at first. But no—worse than that. Instruction. Demonstration. A lesson administered without mercy or explanation.

He did not want to die. That was the one thought that remained clear.

He considered the bullhorn and rejected it. Night magnified everything. Sound carried too far. There were things that moved only after dark.

The sobbing surprised him. It came without warning and once begun could not be stopped. His body shook; the night insects receded, replaced by the sound of his own breath breaking.

Then the cart jolted.

Weight settled behind him.

Tibor froze.

Something was climbing aboard. He could neither turn nor strike accurately in the dark. His extensor would be guesswork; one wrong movement and he would waste his only defense.

A cold, damp touch brushed his neck. Fur followed.

A tongue passed across his cheek.

"Toby," Tibor whispered.

The dog stood beside him, muzzle lifted, tail wagging. Its outline cut against the faint starlight.

"You came back," Tibor said. "Good dog. Good dog."

He spoke carefully, controlling his voice. "Stay with me. Curl up here. I don't have food. I hope you found something. Stay anyway."

He laughed once, thinly. "I can't pet you. I'd crush you. But stay."

The dog settled, warm and solid.

"If I live through the night," Tibor said, "it will be because of you."

The dog thumped its tail.

"I promise you this," Tibor said, suddenly fierce. "If I live, and if someday you are in danger, I will come. You will hear it before you see me. Brush breaking. Stones rolling. I will come from wherever I am. That is my vow."

The dog shifted, content.

Pete Sands walked by moonlight, following the faint double track of the cart. The plain felt exposed, emptied. He should have stopped earlier, found shelter, but distance from the autofac mattered more than comfort.

The tracks wavered.

Without the lubricant, that wheel would seize.

Pete flexed his hip. Sore. His knee ached. His hat was gone; his scalp would burn again tomorrow.

How strong are those extensor arms? he wondered. Strong enough? Against what?

Thoughts of *Luftzeug* intruded and would not be dismissed. If he really existed as a man—aged, domestic, ordinary—what then? What if he had learned to pet dogs, to soften himself? What if he had children?

Too many questions. Pete forced himself to stop supposing.

The gravel swallowed the tracks. He searched, failed, and decided to continue straight. Morning would reveal what night concealed.

Then he saw fire.

A small blaze burned among stones. One figure knelt beside it, helmet spiked, posture relaxed.

Pete slowed. Hunger stirred painfully.

He approached.

The helmet was unmistakable.

"Hunter," Pete said.

The man laughed, deep and easy. "Sit. I hate eating alone."

Pete dropped his pack and joined him.

"I thought you were dead."

"I can see why," the man said, turning meat on a spit. "Blood confuses people."

"How did you escape?"

"One twist too many for it," the man said mildly. "That was all."

He handed Pete a skewer. Pete ate without asking questions.

Skill, Pete thought. Precision. A man built for function.

"You left the C alive," Pete said.

"It wanted to live."

"What became of your bicycle?" the man asked.

"It became pogo sticks."

The hunter smiled. "They do that."

"You're carrying lubricant," he added.

"Someone else's order."

"Good. He'll need it."

Pete looked at him.

"My name is Jack Schuld," the man said.

"I know," Pete replied.

Schuld watched him carefully.

"You're looking for Tibor McMasters," Pete said.

"Yes."

"To protect him," Pete said.

"To use him," Schuld corrected.

Silence stretched.

"You mean to lead him to Lufteufel," Pete said finally.

"Yes."

"And then?"

"I will kill him."

Pete exhaled slowly.

"You're asking me to cooperate."

"I am."

Pete thought of Tibor alone in the dark, the dog curled beside him, the cart immobile.

“Yes,” Pete said at last. “I will.”

Schuld’s hand rested briefly on his shoulder.

Above them, the stars burned on, indifferent and exact.

Chapter 15

The Repair

Morning entered the world in fragments.

First the birds—questioning notes, tentative, then assured. Then dew, a faint breath on metal and leaf, retreating as the light strengthened. Bands of color slipped away from the east, thinning into blue. Tibor lay slumped in the collapsed cart like a wax figure left too near heat, half softened, half preserved. Beside him the dog sat alert, ears cocked, watching the day assemble itself.

Tibor yawned. Blinked. Memory returned slowly.

He tightened his shoulder muscles, released them. Isometrics. Bunch, relax. Bunch, relax.

“Good morning, Toby,” he said. “Another day. This one may decide things.”

The dog wagged once.

“You’re a good dog,” Tibor said. “The best I’ve known. You can go now—see if you can find breakfast. It’s the only way you’ll eat.”

Toby jumped down, relieved himself by a tree, circled the cart, and vanished into the brush. Tibor activated his extensor and attended to his own small necessities.

I should try the bullhorn again, he thought. And immediately: I don’t want to.

If it fails, there is nothing left.

He waited. He searched the sky, the trees. The blue jay? Or only the habit of looking?

He stalled, inventing reasons. Coffee would be good. One last cup. The thought made him smile bitterly.

“All right,” he said. “Enough.”

He raised the horn.

“Hallo. This is Tibor McMasters. I have had an accident. My cart is disabled. I am trapped. If anyone can hear me—can you help me?”

Silence.

He waited. Tried again. Again nothing.

Three more calls. An hour uncoiled and was spent. Toby returned, conferred briefly with the cow, lay down in the shade.

Then—something.

A sound that might have been a shout, or only the ear reshaping hope into noise.

Tibor held his breath.

Toby rose. Ears forward. Body rigid.

Tibor lifted the horn again.

“Hallo! Over here! I am trapped! This is Tibor McMasters—can you hear me?”

“Yes!” The word carried clearly. “We are coming!”

Tibor laughed, softly at first, then openly. His eyes burned. For an instant he thought he saw a blue shape dart among the trees, but certainty escaped him.

“We’ll finish this Pilg yet,” he told the dog. “I think we will.”

Ten minutes later Pete Sands and Jack Schuld came around the bend. Toby flattened his ears and growled, backing against the cart.

“It’s all right,” Tibor said. “I know one of them.”

Pete called, “Tibor! Are you hurt?”

“Just the cart,” Tibor replied. “Lost a wheel.”

They approached.

“I see it,” Pete said. “This is Jack Schuld. Jack—Tibor McMasters.”

“I can’t shake hands,” Tibor said.

Schuld smiled. “I’ll lend you mine.”

He retrieved the wheel easily, rolling it forward. Nimble, Tibor thought. Effortless. The kind of movement one notices only after years without it.

Toby snarled.

“Easy,” Tibor said. “They’re helping.”

Pete brought the lubricant.

“We’ll need to raise it.”

“I’ll do that,” Schuld said.

As they worked, Tibor said, “I suppose I should ask what brought you this way.”

Pete looked up, sighed. "You didn't want me along. I followed anyway. For exactly this reason."

"I'm not ungrateful," Tibor said. "Thank you."

"May I stay?" Pete asked.

"I can't object now," Tibor said. "That's as close to consent as you'll get."

Schuld laughed as he lifted the cart.

"Fit it now," he said.

They worked efficiently. Pete tightened the nut.

"I appreciate it," Tibor said.

"Glad to help," Schuld replied. "I hear you're on a Pilg."

"That's right."

"Looking for Lufteufel."

"Yes."

Schuld nodded. "Rumors say the town north of here. Easy to miss. He's said to live outside it. Different name now. A veterinarian."

"Do you believe that?"

"I think the odds are good."

Pete said nothing.

The cart rolled smoothly again.

"Better," Tibor said. "Much better."

They set out together.

That evening, as they gathered wood, Pete said quietly to Schuld, "You convinced him."

"Pride," Schuld said. "Reliable."

"I'd like a walk after dinner."

"Please."

Later, Schuld said, "I'll tell him I was mistaken. That should satisfy him."

Pete nodded. "That would help."

"You want him never to see Lufteufel."

"Yes."

"And afterward?"

"I don't know. But he'll be removed from our concern."

Schuld considered. "Very well. We'll do it your way."

Pete exhaled.

As they returned, Toby appeared suddenly, snarling. Schuld kicked him aside.

"Damn dog," he said. "It hates me."

Pete watched the dog retreat, unhurt but wary.

Yes, he thought. It does.
And it knows why.

Chapter 16

The Broken Neck

Pete Sands set up his radio by moonlight in a small glade a quarter mile back along the road. He worked methodically, hands steady, breath controlled.

Neat, he thought, how it worked out. Schuld suggesting the walk I needed anyway.

He plugged in the earphone and brought the transmitter to life.

“Dr. Abernathy,” he said. “This is Pete Sands.”

Static, then: “Go ahead, Pete.”

“I’ve found Tibor. We’re traveling together now. I’m calling from just outside our camp.”

A pause. “What are your plans?”

“They’ve become complicated. There’s a third man with us—Jack Schuld. He claims to know where Lufteufel is. He’s offered to guide us there. We may reach the place tomorrow.”

Pete heard the intake of breath and continued before it could turn into interruption.

“I made an arrangement. Schuld will tell Tibor he was mistaken. We’ll bypass Lufteufel and go on.”

“Pete,” Abernathy said, “that makes no sense. Why involve him at all?”

“Because he’s going there anyway,” Pete said. “And because he’s dangerous.”

Silence.

“All right,” Pete added. “He’s an assassin. He intends to kill Lufteufel. He believes traveling with an inc makes him less visible.”

“Pete. That makes you complicit in murder.”

"I don't see it that way. I can't stop him. And I don't know that what he intends is murder in the strict sense. He claims authority. I thought you'd be relieved—"

"Relieved at a man's death?" Abernathy said. "No."

"Then suggest something else."

"Get away from him. Take Tibor and leave."

"Against Tibor's will?"

Static answered.

Finally: "You must find a way."

"I'll try," Pete said. "But it doesn't look possible."

"I'll pray," Abernathy said. "Call again tomorrow."

Pete shut the set down and disassembled it carefully. Crickets filled the space.

Back at the fire, Schuld stirred the embers. "Tibor McMasters," he said lightly. "On his way to immortality."

Tibor blinked. He had been watching the flames resolve into the face of a woman he had loved once.

"Immortality," Schuld repeated. "Better than progeny. Painting outlasts flesh."

He quoted easily, beautifully—Leonardo, the primacy of image over name. Tibor listened, drawn in.

"You will be remembered," Schuld said, "not for descendants but for vision."

Tibor smiled. "It is a responsibility."

"It's more than that," Schuld said softly. "Charlottesville was chosen for you. I chose you."

Tibor turned. "You?"

Schuld's face pulsed in the firelight. "I lead the Servants of Wrath. I wanted you as my artist."

"My God," Tibor said.

"Yes," Schuld said. "I waited to tell you. Pete could not hear this."

Tibor absorbed it. It fit. Too well.

"I believe you," Tibor said finally.

"You must be ready," Schuld said. "The moment may come suddenly."

"I will be."

Pete returned from the glade with Toby at his heels. Wine was passed. Words followed—about faith, fracture, history. Schuld pressed. Pete resisted. The air tightened.

Then Toby yelped.

Tibor reacted instantly, driving the cart toward the sound.

They burst through brush into shadow and blood.

The dog lay twisted, neck broken.

Schuld stood nearby, calm. "Necessary," he said. "A reflex."

Rage broke through Tibor like lightning. The extensor lashed out, struck Schuld, sent him reeling.

"Murderer!" Tibor cried.

"No!" Pete shouted, running forward. "Stop!"

Schuld ran. The extensor caught his feet, flung him down. Pete interposed himself, arms raised.

"Tibor! Don't! You'll kill him!"

The extensor struck Pete aside, lifted him, hurled him into brush.

When he rose, tangled and breathless, he heard the choking sound.

Schuld hung suspended, gripped by the throat. His eyes bulged; his body shuddered, then slackened.

"No," Pete said quietly.

It was finished.

Pete covered his eyes too late.

It was meant for me, he thought. He wanted me to do it. To reveal him at the moment of death. Ecce. Ecce.

But Tibor had acted first. Blind with grief. Blind with rage.

May you never know, Pete prayed silently. May you never understand what you have done.

Amen.

Chapter 17

The Substitute

Rain. A gray world, chilled and blurred. Idaho. Basque country. Sheep on slopes. Jai alai courts long since empty. A language they say even the Devil could not master.

Pete trudged beside the creaking cart. Thank God, he thought, it had not been hard to convince Tibor that Lufteufel's place lay nowhere near where Schuld had said it was. Two weeks now. Two weeks since it happened, and Tibor was still hurting. He must never know how close he came.

Schuld was a madman to him now. Pete wished he could believe that, too.

The burial had been the hardest part. I should have said something, he thought. A prayer. Anything. But my mouth was empty. My lips would not move. He had stood there mute, as useless as the girl they passed the next day—sitting at a crossroads, a broken doll in her lap, staring at nothing.

After all, the man had been human. He had had a soul.

They went on.

A necessary errand of fools. So long as Tibor believed Lufteufel still lay somewhere ahead, they had to keep moving. Forever, if need be. Searching for a man already dead. It was Tibor's fault too, Pete knew—believing that the vision of God could be captured in pigment, that an epiphany could be rendered with color and line. Presumption. And yet—

He needs me now more than ever.

"We go on," Pete murmured.

"Did you say something?" Tibor asked from the cart.

"Just that we're ridiculous."

"Why?"

"We haven't the sense to get out of the rain."

Tibor snorted. Elevated, he could see farther.

"There's a building down the hill," he said. "Part of a barn, maybe. Beyond that—something more. A settlement, perhaps."

"Let's head for the barn."

"We're already soaked."

"This rain's hard on your cart."

"That's true." A pause. "All right. The barn."

Pete pointed as it came into view. "A painter named Wyeth liked scenes like that."

"Barns?" Tibor asked.

"Yes."

"Was he good?"

"I think so."

"Why?"

"They looked real."

Tibor laughed softly. "There are infinite ways of showing how things look. All are true. Each artist chooses emphasis."

"You've painted," Pete said.

"Yes."

A thought struck him then.

"When we find Lufteufel—if we had—how would you have known the right way to show him?"

Tibor shook his head. "There are many ways. But only one best."

"How do you know?"

Silence.

"You just do," Tibor said at last. "It feels right."

Pete waited.

"Neither do I," Tibor added quietly.

Inside the barn there was straw. Pete unhitched the cow and closed the door. Rain dripped through holes in the roof. The air smelled sweet and damp.

He lay back, exhausted. God, I'm tired.

He had not called Abernathy since the night after it happened. Nothing new to say. Go on, Abernathy had told him. Lead him through the land. Continue to search. My prayers go with you.

It was the only way.

Sleep came and went.

When Pete woke, the rain had stopped. Tibor snored lightly. The cow chewed. Pete stretched and sat up.

Tibor lay awake, staring at beams.

If He had not taken back my arms and legs, Tibor thought, I could never have killed that man. Only the manipulators made it possible. Why give me the tools to kill?

Things had seemed so near completion. Hope, then despair. Perhaps Pete was right. How does one show such a being? How does one paint wrath?

I miss Toby.

He had been a good dog.

I was wrong to accept this commission. Pride brought me here.

Pete stirred.

"Tibor?"

"Yes?"

"Where's that snoring coming from?"

"I thought it was you."

Pete moved toward a stall.

"A bum," he said after a moment. "Sleeping it off."

"Maybe he knows something," Tibor suggested.

Pete doubted it.

The man moaned. "Where are you?"

Pete hesitated.

"Maybe he's sick," Tibor said.

"I don't doubt it."

"Help old Tom," the voice croaked.

Pete knelt beside him, breathing shallowly. The man reeked of wine and decay. Broken teeth. Scars. Tremors beneath the skin.

"Hold the jug," Tom pleaded.

Pete did.

Between coughs, the man spoke of Denver. A nice city. Burned. Pete listened.

On impulse, he asked, "Do you know who Carleton Lufteufel was?"

Tom shook his head.

Pete thought fast. Faster than he wanted to.

An idea—absurd, desperate—took shape.

"Would you do a kindness?" Pete asked.

Tom squinted. "For a drink."

Pete poured.

“Say you’re Carleton Lufteufel,” Pete said. “Just that.”

Tom blinked. Then smiled.

“Name’s Carleton Lufteufel,” he said.

Tibor gasped.

“I gave the bomb order,” Tom added, obediently.

Tibor activated the camera.

It does not matter, Tibor thought. I will do the best I can.

The picture was taken.

Home, Tibor thought. We can go home.

That night they sat by a small fire. Stars burned clean in the washed sky.

Coffee steamed.

“There were times,” Tibor said, “when I thought I’d never make it.”

Pete nodded.

“Still mad I came?”

Tibor smiled faintly. “Hell of a way to get converts.”

“Still thinking about it?”

“Yes.”

Pete looked at the stars.

“It’s over,” he thought.

“Too bad,” he said aloud, “I couldn’t find cigarettes.”

And the night went on.

Chapter 18

The Membrane

At the side of the dust-run that served as a road, Alice sat in silence. A long while passed. The sun climbed, held its place, then declined, and at last darkness came. She knew he was dead even before the lizzy approached her.

“Miss.”

She did not look up.

“Miss, come along with us.”

“No!” she said, sharply.

“The cadaver—”

“I no want!”

The lizzy settled beside her, patient. “By custom, you’re supposed to claim it.” Time passed. Alice shut her eyes. With her hands over her ears she could not tell whether it spoke again. At last something touched her shoulder.

“You’re a retard, aren’t you?”

“No.”

“You’re too retarded to know what I’m saying. He was dressed as a hunter, but he was the old man you lived with—the rat man. That’s who he was, wasn’t it? Disguised. Trying to get away from enemies.” The lizzy laughed, scales rasping. “Didn’t work. They bashed his face in. You should see it—nothing but pulp and—”

She leapt up and ran, then ran back for her doll. The lizzy had it now. It grinned, holding it to its chest, mocking her.

“He good man!” she cried, scrabbling.

“No. Not even a good rat catcher. Sold old tough rats as young ones half the time. What did he do before that?”

Alice whispered, "Bombs."

"Your daddy."

"Yes. My daddy."

"Well, since he was your daddy, we'll bring you the corpse." The lizzy dropped the doll and ambled off.

Alice sat holding it, tears running soundlessly. Knew it wouldn't work, she thought. Knew they'd get him. Maybe for bad rats. Tough old ones.

Why is it like this? she wondered. He gave me this doll. Now he won't give me anything again. Ever.

She rocked, eyes shut.

When she opened them, a man who was not a lizzy was coming down the road. Her daddy.

She rose, joyful—then stopped. Something had changed. He stood straighter. His face was kind, calm, untroubled. No twistedness remained.

He approached slowly, solemnly, like a dancer. He sat and motioned for her to sit too. He did not speak.

She reached out. Her fingers passed through his arm.

Then she knew.

"Can you hear me?" she asked.

He smiled and nodded.

Understanding flowed through her—clear, sudden, complete. As if a membrane had been stripped from her mind. The world made sense.

"I love you," she said.

He smiled.

"Will I see you again?"

He nodded.

"But I have to pass across first."

He nodded again.

"You feel better," she said. "The evil is gone from you."

He rose and began to walk away.

"Wait."

He did not stop.

He passed through debris without touching it, dwindling, thinning, becoming light, then nothing. But something remained. A trace. A presence.

Two lizzys arrived, puzzled.

"It's gone," one said. "Your corpse."

"Yes," Alice said.

"Stolen," the other guessed.

“It rose,” she said.

They laughed.

Then one grew uneasy. “Did you hear that word she used?”

Alice turned away, clutching her doll. The particles of light brushed past her, lingering.

The membrane never returned.

She walked on, thinking: We have advanced one step along the manifold.

Dr. Abernathy felt the world lighten as he walked back from market. The air smelled of ozone. Of spring.

Something good has happened, he thought.

Palm trees rustled nearby. He stopped, astonished. A Levantine warmth. A clarity.

Young people rested by the road. A girl laughed, bare and unashamed. The film is gone, he thought.

Some evil has perished.

He laughed softly. Gods have nothing to fear from cameras—except exposure.

Walking on, basket in hand, he felt the world renewed.

Perhaps it is better not to know, he thought.

And he went on toward Charlottesville.

Chapter 19

The Murch

The murch painted by Tibor McMasters spread slowly across the world. At first it circulated as rumor, then as reproduction, then as destination. In time it came to be judged equal to the works of the great Italian masters, most of whose originals no longer existed and were known only through imperfect prints. In this sense, Tibor's work belonged naturally among them: an image surviving a ruined age.

Seventeen years after Tibor's death, the hierarchy of the Servants of Wrath issued a final and binding declaration of authenticity. The image was proclaimed to be, beyond question, the true visage of the God of Wrath—Carleton Luftefel. All debate ended there. To dispute the identification was henceforth illegal. The penalties were explicit: emasculation for men, removal of one ear for women. These measures were instituted to secure reverence in an irreverent world, faith in a society that had misplaced it, belief in a culture that had learned—too late—that much of what it once believed had been lies.

At the time of his death, Tibor subsisted on a modest annual pension from the Church, supplemented by guaranteed upkeep of his cart and fodder for two cows. Because of the excellence of his work he had been granted two animals instead of one. As he traveled, people recognized him and called out to him. Tourists requested autographs, which he gave with effort and patience. Children shouted his name, but did not jeer. He was liked. Though he grew eccentric and irritable with age, he was regarded as an asset to the community. This esteem endured despite the fact that, after completing the true portrait of the God of Wrath, Tibor McMasters never again produced a work of significance.

It was rumored that among his personal effects were fragments of a

diary—private notes written only for himself—in which, late in life, he recorded certain doubts regarding the authenticity of his own great murch. No such documents were ever produced. If they existed at all, the Servants of Wrath, who took possession of his papers after his death, either sealed them behind locked metal doors or, more probably, destroyed them.

Tibor's last two cows were slaughtered, preserved, and mounted—one on each side of the murch—to stare solemnly, glass-eyed, at the pilgrims and tourists who came to pay homage to the painting. Tibor McMasters himself was eventually canonized by the Church. His grave site is unknown. Several cities claim it, proudly.

And so he entered history as the man who had seen God, and shown Him— and as the one who, having done so, could paint nothing more.

Epilogue

The Membrane Thins

Dr. Abernathy walked at the edge of Charlottesville where the town gave up and the land resumed its own grammar. The rain had ended before dawn, but the air retained a sharpness that did not belong to any season he knew. It smelled faintly of ozone and wet stone, the way storms once did when storms were still part of a larger conversation. There was warmth, too—wrong warmth—rising from the ground in shallow breaths. He felt it through the soles of his shoes.

A palm frond lay beside the road, green and intact, as if dropped rather than grown. He did not stop to examine it. He had learned, lately, that looking too closely was a form of assent.

The world felt unfilmed. Not joyous—only exposed. Light without permission.

He recognized the sensation. It had come before, briefly, and passed. Now it lingered.

Ahead, by the split-rail fence where the old irrigation ditch curved away, Pete Sands stood waiting. He had aged into himself. His hair had gone thin and pale; his shoulders sloped as if accommodating an invisible weight. His hands moved with the old habits intact—small calibrations, unconscious spacing, the reflexes of a man who had once trusted equipment to listen for him. They never quite stopped moving.

Pete saw him and straightened.

“Father—”

“Doctor,” Abernathy said gently.

They stood there a moment, the correction hanging between them, not as rebuke but as recognition. Names were masks; both of them knew that now.

Pete swallowed. “I need to tell you what I did.”

Abernathy began walking again, slowly, and Pete fell into step beside him. Gravel shifted underfoot. Somewhere nearby, water ran where water had not run in years.

“You need someone to suffer with you,” Abernathy said. “That is different.”

Pete’s mouth tightened. “He’s a saint because of a photograph.”

Abernathy nodded once. “He’s a saint because people needed him to be.”

They walked on. The road curved. The town remained behind them, quiet and intact, as if nothing had ever trembled beneath it.

Pete said, “If the world is thinning—if that’s what this is—shouldn’t we be honest now?”

Abernathy stopped. He placed one hand on the fence rail, feeling the grain, the slight give of damp wood. When he spoke, his voice was level.

“When the floorboards loosen,” he said, “you don’t start a stampede.”

Pete let out a breath that was almost a laugh. “So you forgive me?”

Abernathy turned to him then. “No,” he said. “I refuse to make your sin useful.”

Pete flinched—not at the words, but at their precision.

“Then what do I do?”

Abernathy looked down the road, toward the fields where the light pooled oddly, as if collecting itself. “You keep walking,” he said. “You keep one person from becoming a slogan.”

They stood together in the quiet. A bird perched on the fencepost above them—a small, ordinary thing, brown and alert. It tilted its head and sang. The notes arranged themselves too carefully, resolving into something that was almost a hymn, though not one Abernathy recognized. The cadence was wrong. The intelligence of it was wrong.

He noticed. And did not name it.

Instead, he reached into the pocket of his coat and drew out a piece of bread, wrapped in cloth, slightly stale. From his other pocket he took a small flask of water.

“Sit,” he said.

They sat on the low stone wall by the ditch. Abernathy broke the bread with his hands and passed half to Pete. He handed him the water.

No words followed. There was no formula, no blessing spoken. They ate. They drank. They sat while the light strengthened and the warmth spread, and the world, for the moment, held.

Pete did not feel forgiven. But his hands stopped shaking.

And that, Abernathy thought, would have to be enough—for now.

Sealed Artifact

Servants of Wrath — Central Archive

Catalog Reference: M-IR/ Δ -117

Subject: Tibor McMasters

Material Type: Personal holographs (fragmentary)

Medium: Ink on paper, degraded

Recovery Status: Partial

Assessment: Destabilizing

Fragment recovered from effects; ink faded; syntax irregular.

Content reviewed by doctrinal committee and found to be inconsistent with established Visage doctrine.

Determination: non-canonical, corrosive to faith coherence.

Disposition: Incinerated.

Date: [REDACTED]

Authorization: [REDACTED]

Addendum (procedural note):

No certified copies were made. No photographic record exists.

Secondary testimony is inadmissible.

Supplementary Notice (internal circulation only):

It is forbidden to ask whether a face is true.

A face is what the Church decides.

Excerpt from Tourist Brochure (undated, revised edition):

“... the murch was executed from the final photograph taken during the Pilg, preserved against the ravages of time and chance. Some visitors remark upon the humble setting of that last sitting—variously described as a barn, a shelter, or a roadside enclosure. Such details belong to folklore and should not distract from the eternal authority of the Visage itself.”

File closed.

Kindness, Practiced Quietly

Lurine arrived at the murch on foot, not because she meant to, but because that was how it worked out. The bus stopped short of the outer fence, and the last mile was given over to animals and people who had paid for animals: cows with braided tails and polished horns, carts rented by the hour, boys shouting prices for shade and water and commemorative prints. The air rang with bells and recorded hymns and argument. Reverence had learned how to sell itself.

She stood for a time at the edge of it, pack slung over one shoulder, feeling older than she expected to feel. Not bitter—just tired, in the way one becomes tired of insisting. She had once believed that kindness could win an argument. She no longer believed that. She still believed it mattered.

The murch dominated the far wall, enormous and inevitable. People queued before it in orderly lines, their faces lifted, some weeping, some bored, some intent on the instructions whispered into their ears by guides in gray. Lurine waited her turn without hurry.

When she finally stood before the image, she did not gasp. She did not laugh. She felt, instead, the peculiar tightening that comes when something is both ridiculous and dangerous at once. A face magnified until it became law. A likeness burdened with commandments it had never asked for.

She did not ask herself whom it resembled. She did not ask herself why.

A young Servant guide stood beside her, reciting softly to a cluster of visitors. He was earnest, barely grown, his robe too large for him.

“Do you accept the Visage as true?” he asked her, by rote.

Lurine looked at him—not at the image, but at the boy. “I accept that you’re afraid,” she said.

His mouth opened, closed. “It is illegal to dispute it.”

“Then don’t dispute it,” she said mildly. “Just don’t let it make you cruel.”

A child tugged at her sleeve then, a pilgrim girl with dust on her cheeks and a paper token tied around her wrist.

“Did you come to see God?” the child asked.

Lurine smiled, small and honest. “I came to see what people do when they think they have.”

The air inside the murch felt different than she remembered air feeling anywhere. Less static. More warmth. As if the world were listening back, just a little. She hated that she noticed. She hated more that she liked it.

I like kind people, she remembered thinking once, long ago. It felt now like both prophecy and accusation.

Near the side aisle, a man knelt with his head bowed, one ear crudely bandaged, blood already seeping through the cloth. A dissenter, probably. Someone who had said one sentence too many. The guards nearby were bored; the punishment had been administered and recorded. There was nothing left to see.

Lurine knelt beside him without asking permission. She took water from her pack, cleaned the wound properly, replaced the bandage with one of her own. She pressed bread into his hand. Not much. Enough.

“Eat slowly,” she said.

He looked at her as if she might vanish. She did not stay long enough to test the theory.

When she stood and turned away, no one stopped her. No one praised her. The image remained, immense and untroubled, absorbing devotion and coin alike.

Lurine walked out past the cows and the shouting vendors and the bells. She did not feel victorious. She did not feel defeated.

A face could be a prison. So could a story.

She walked out anyway.

What Walks After

Alice walked the road with the doll under her arm. The road felt new, though it was old enough to remember carts and fires and running feet. Plants grew where plants should not have grown—thin grasses threading through cracked asphalt, a vine flowering out of rust. The light lay softly on things, not bright, not dim, as if it had learned restraint.

Birds moved along the fence lines and spoke more than they should have. Not songs, exactly. Statements. Registrations. The world, she thought, was restarting itself without asking anyone’s permission.

She was not fixed. She was clear.

The membrane had shifted. She did not know how else to say it, and she did not try to say more. Words were tools; this did not require many.

A runner came along the road toward her—one of the polite ones, long-legged, moving with the careful efficiency of a clerk late for an appointment. It slowed when it saw her.

“Clearness be with you,” it said.

“Yes,” Alice said. “It is with me.”

The runner inclined its head. “Do you seek the Visage?”

“No,” she said. “I seek the door that opens behind the face.”

The runner considered this, consulting nothing visible. “You will have to pass across first.”

“I know,” Alice said. “My father told me.”

It nodded, satisfied, and went on its way, ticking softly as it receded.

A bird settled on the signpost ahead of her. Its eyes were bright and unworried.

“You can understand me now,” it said.

“I always could,” Alice replied. “I just didn’t have permission.”

She passed a ruined building half-swallowed by vines. A plaque clung to its wall, the letters worn nearly away. She could make out only the beginning: HAGIA . . . The rest had been claimed by weather and time. Someone had scratched a symbol into the metal below it—something like a crown, or a ring, or a light seen edge-on.

The words Holy Wisdom followed her for a while. She did not know why. She did not try to decide whether they belonged to the past or the future.

She did not turn toward the murch. That mattered. She knew it mattered, even if she could not have explained to whom. Institutions had endings. Doors did not.

Behind her, the world kept its relics. Ahead, it learned new words.

Notes